

MCPShield Study Guide — Model Context Protocol & Project Mastery

Purpose: A comprehensive 15+ page guide to master the Model Context Protocol (MCP) and the MCPShield project for the workshop event.

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1. What is MCP?

Definition

Model Context Protocol (MCP) is an open protocol developed by Anthropic that standardizes how AI applications (LLMs) communicate with external tools and data sources. Think of it as "USB-C for AI" — a universal connector between AI models and the systems they interact with.

Core Concepts

Concept	Description	MCPShield Example
Host	The AI application that initiates connections	Slack bot / Dashboard chat
Client	A connector that maintains a 1:1 connection with a server	MCP Client in agent and API
Server	A program that exposes tools, resources, and prompts	MCP Server with 11 tools
Tool	An executable function the AI can call	scan_environment, list_findings
Resource	Data that can be read by the AI (like files)	(Not used in MCPShield)
Prompt	Pre-written templates for the AI	(Not used in MCPShield)

The MCP Handshake

1. Client connects to Server (via STDIO or SSE)
2. Client sends `initialize` request
3. Server responds with capabilities (tools, resources, prompts)
4. Client sends `tools/list` to discover available tools
5. Client sends `tools/call` with tool name + arguments
6. Server executes and returns result

Why MCP Instead of Direct API Calls?

- **Security Boundary** — The AI never gets raw API credentials
- **Abstraction** — Tool interface stays stable while underlying APIs change
- **Observability** — Every tool call can be logged, rate-limited, and audited
- **Interoperability** — Any MCP-compatible client can use any MCP server

2. MCP Architecture & Protocol

JSON-RPC 2.0

MCP uses **JSON-RPC 2.0** as its wire protocol. Every message is a JSON object with:

```
{
  "jsonrpc": "2.0",
  "id": 1,
  "method": "tools/call",
  "params": {
    "name": "scan_environment",
    "arguments": {}
  }
}
```

Message Types

Direction	Method	Purpose
Client → Server	initialize	Start session, negotiate version
Server → Client	initialized	Acknowledge session start
Client → Server	tools/list	List all available tools
Server → Client	tools/list result	Array of tool definitions
Client → Server	tools/call	Execute a specific tool
Server → Client	tools/call result	Tool execution result
Server → Client	notifications/tools/list_changed	Tell client to refresh tool list

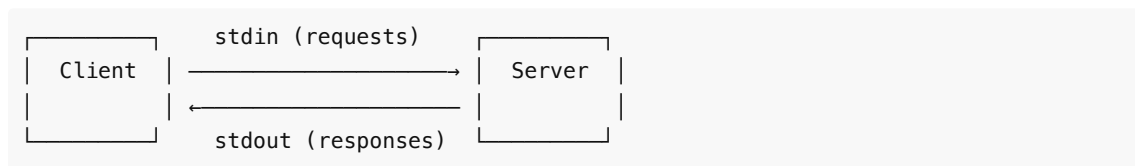
Tool Definition Schema

```
{
  "name": "scan_environment",
  "description": "Scan the active AWS environment to catalog resources and detect misconfigurations.",
  "inputSchema": {
    "type": "object",
    "properties": {
      "services": {
        "type": "array",
        "items": { "type": "string" },
        "description": "Optional subset of AWS services to scan"
      }
    }
  }
}
```

3. Transport Layer: STDIO vs SSE

STDIO Transport

The client spawns the server as a child process and communicates via `stdin / stdout`.



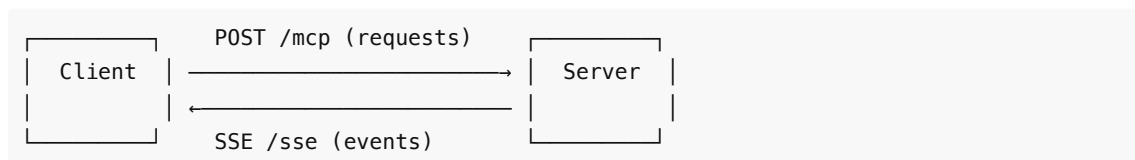
Use case: Local development, same-machine deployment.

MCPSHIELD STDIO Client (agent):

```
transport = new StdioClientTransport({
  command: 'node',
  args: ['../../mcp-server/dist/index.js'],
  env: { ...process.env, MCP_TRANSPORT: 'stdio' },
});
```

SSE Transport (Server-Sent Events)

The client connects to an HTTP endpoint. The server pushes events to the client.



Use case: Docker, remote servers, multi-process deployments.

MCPSHIELD SSE Server:

```
// Fastify SSE endpoint
app.get('/sse', (request, reply) => {
  // Stream events to client
});

app.post('/mcp', (request, reply) => {
  // Handle JSON-RPC requests
});
```

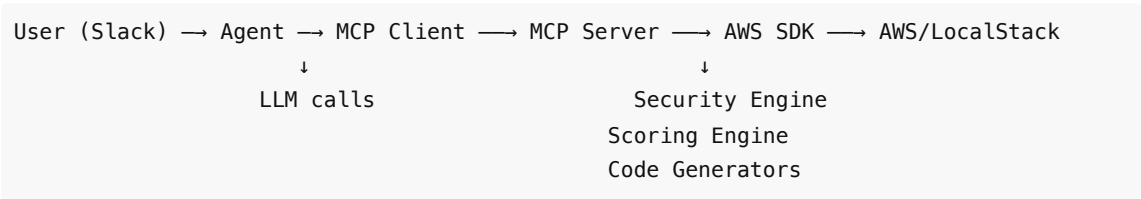
MCPShield Transport Decision

The agent and API check MCP_TRANSPORT env var:

Value	Transport	When Used
stdio	STDIO	Local pnpm dev
http	SSE via MCP_SERVER_URL	Docker / production

4. MCP in MCPShield

Communication Flow



Key Security Principle

The AI (LLM) NEVER communicates directly with AWS. ALL operations pass through MCP tools.

This ensures:

- No raw AWS credentials expose to the LLM
- Every action is logged and auditable
- Human approval gates write operations

Tool Execution Flow

1. User: @Shield scan environment
2. Agent receives Slack event
3. Agent calls mcpClient.callTool({ name: 'scan_environment' })
4. MCP Client sends JSON-RPC to MCP Server
5. MCP Server runs scanEnvironment() → runSecurityEngine()
6. MCP Server returns ScanResult
7. Agent formats and sends response

5. Project Anatomy

Monorepo Structure

```
mcpshield/
├── apps/
│   ├── agent/           # Slack bot + LLM integration
│   ├── api/             # REST API (dashboard backend)
│   ├── dashboard/       # Web dashboard SPA
│   └── mcp-server/      # MCP tool server
├── packages/
│   ├── types/           # Zod schemas + TypeScript types
│   ├── config/          # Env config loader
│   ├── logger/          # Pino logger
│   ├── shared/          # Utilities (IDs, timers, Result)
│   ├── aws-tools/       # AWS SDK clients, scanner, remediator
│   ├── security-engine/ # 21 security rules
│   ├── finding-engine/  # Finding catalog + registry
│   ├── scoring-engine/  # Score calculator
│   ├── llm/             # Shared LLM adapters
│   ├── terraform-generator/ # HCL generation
│   ├── aws-cli-generator/ # CLI generation
│   └── report-generator/ # Report generation
└── docker/              # Dockerfiles
```

Dependency Graph

```
agent  → mcp-client → MCP Server
api    → mcp-client → MCP Server
      ↓
MCP Server → aws-tools → AWS SDK
MCP Server → security-engine
MCP Server → scoring-engine
MCP Server → terraform-generator
MCP Server → aws-cli-generator
MCP Server → report-generator

aws-tools → types
security-engine → types
scoring-engine → types
all → config → types
all → logger
```

Tech Stack

Layer	Technology
Runtime	Node.js 22+, TypeScript strict mode
Package Manager	pnpm workspaces (v11)

MCP	@modelcontextprotocol/sdk v1
HTTP	Fastify v5
Validation	Zod
Logging	Pino
Slack	@slack/bolt (Socket Mode)
Cloud SDK	AWS SDK v3
Testing	Vitest

6. The 11 MCP Tools

Tool Inventory

#	Tool Name	Read/Write	Description
1	scan_environment	Read	Scan AWS services for resources and misconfigurations
2	list_findings	Read	Retrieve findings from the last scan
3	describe_finding	Read	Get full details for a specific finding
4	security_score	Read	Compute current security posture score
5	generate_report	Read	Generate executive Markdown report
6	generate_cli_fix	Read	Generate AWS CLI remediation commands
7	generate_terraform_fix	Read	Generate Terraform HCL remediation
8	approve_remediation	Write	Approve findings for remediation
9	execute_remediation	Write	Apply approved remediations to AWS
10	rescan_environment	Read	Re-scan environment (wrapper around scan + score)
11	health	Read	Check server connectivity and status

Tool 1: scan_environment

```
Input: { services?: AwsService[] }
Output: ScanResult {
  scanId: string,
  startedAt: string,
  completedAt: string,
  endpoint: string,
  region: string,
  resourcesScanned: number,
  resourceCounts: Record<string, number>,
}
```

```
    findings: Finding[],
    score?: SecurityScore
}
```

Execution:

1. loadState() from disk
2. scanEnvironment(services) → ResourceSnapshot[]
3. runSecurityEngine(snapshots) → Finding[]
4. Merge with existing findings (lifecycle tracking)
5. computeSecurityScore(findings) → SecurityScore
6. saveState(state)
7. Return ScanResult

Tool 2: list_findings

```
Input: { severity?: Severity, service?: AwsService }
Output: { findings: Finding[], total: number }
```

Tool 3: describe_finding

```
Input: { findingId: string }
Output: { finding: Finding, catalog: FindingCatalogEntry }
```

Tool 4: security_score

```
Input: {}
Output: SecurityScore {
  score: number,           // 0-100
  grade: 'A' | 'B' | 'C' | 'D' | 'F',
  totalFindings: number,
  breakdown: {
    critical: number,
    high: number,
    medium: number,
    low: number
  },
  computedAt: string,
  delta?: number           // Change from previous score
}
```

Tool 5: generate_report

```
Input: {}
Output: Report {
  markdown: string,
  score: SecurityScore,
  findings: Finding[],
}
```

```
    recommendations: Recommendation[]
  }
```

Tools 6–7: generate_cli_fix / generate_terraform_fix

```
Input: { findingId: string }
Output: {
  findingId: string,
  content: string,      // Generated code
  summary: string,
  provider: 'terraform' | 'aws-cli'
}
```

Tool 8: approve_remediation

```
Input: {
  findingIds: string[],
  approvedBy: string,
  note?: string
}
Output: Approval {
  approvalId: string,
  findingIds: string[],
  status: 'approved',
  approvedBy: string,
  createdAt: string
}
```

Tool 9: execute_remediation

```
Input: { approvalId: string }
Output: {
  approvalId: string,
  results: RemediationResult[],
  score: SecurityScore
}
```

Execution:

1. Verify approval exists and is 'approved'
2. For each finding:
 - a. Map finding to RemediationAction
 - b. Execute via AWS SDK
 - c. Mark finding as 'resolved' or 'open'
3. Recompute score
4. Save state

Tool 10: rescan_environment


```
Input: {}
Output: ScanResult (same as scan_environment)
```

Tool 11: health

```
Input: {}
Output: {
  status: 'ok' | 'degraded',
  version: string,
  uptimeSeconds: number,
  cloudProvider: {
    reachable: boolean,
    endpoint: string,
    region: string,
    services: Record<string, string>
  },
  lastScanId?: string
}
```

7. Security Engine: 21 Rules

Rule Categories

Severity	Count	Rules
 Critical	3	MCPS-S3-001, MCPS-IAM-001, MCPS-IAM-002
 High	7	MCPS-EC2-001, MCPS-EC2-002, MCPS-S3-002, MCPS-S3-003, MCPS-CT-001, MCPS-SSM-001
 Medium	8	MCPS-IAM-003, MCPS-IAM-004, MCPS-IAM-005, MCPS-S3-004, MCPS-LM-001, MCPS-SQS-001, MCPS-SNS-001, MCPS-DDB-001, MCPS-SEC-001
 Low	3	MCPS-TAG-001, MCPS-NAM-001, MCPS-DESC-001

Rule Implementation Pattern

Each rule is a pure function:

```
function checkPublicS3Bucket(snapshot: ResourceSnapshot): RuleEvaluation | null {
  if (snapshot.service !== 's3' || snapshot.type !== 'bucket') return null;

  const pab = snapshot.attributes.publicAccessBlock;
  let isViolated = false;
  const evidence: Record<string, unknown> = {};

  // Check Block Public Access
  if (!pab || !isFullyBlocked(pab)) {
    isViolated = true;
```

```

    evidence.publicAccessBlockMissing = true;
}

// Check ACLs for public grants
// Check policies for wildcard principals

return { catalogId: 'MCPS-S3-001', isViolated, evidence };
}

```

Rule Functions

#	Function	What It Checks
1	checkPublicS3Bucket	S3 Block Public Access, public ACLs, wildcard policies
2	checkAdminAccessAttached	AdministratorAccess policy on IAM user
3	checkOldAccessKeys	Active keys older than 90 days
4	checkSshOpenToInternet	Security group allows 0.0.0.0/0 on port 22
5	checkRdpOpenToInternet	Security group allows 0.0.0.0/0 on port 3389
6	checkS3MissingEncryption	Bucket has no default SSE
7	checkS3VersioningDisabled	Bucket versioning not enabled
8	checkCloudTrailDisabled	Trail not logging or not multi-region
9	checkWeakPasswordPolicy	IAM password policy below 14 chars / missing complexity
10	checkUnusedUser	User inactive > 90 days
11	checkUnusedAccessKeys	Keys unused > 90 days
12	checkS3LoggingDisabled	Server access logging not configured
13	checkMissingTags	Resource missing Owner/Environment/DataClassification
14	checkNamingConvention	Bucket name doesn't match pattern
15	checkMissingDescriptions	SG/param has no description
16	checkSsmUnencryptedSecret	SSM param with sensitive name not SecureString
17	checkLambdaDeprecatedRuntime	Lambda on outdated runtime
18	checkSqsEncryptionDisabled	SQS queue has no KMS key
19	checkSnsEncryptionDisabled	SNS topic has no KMS key
20	checkDynamoDbDefaultEncryption	DynamoDB table uses default AWS-owned key
21	checkSecretsManagerDefaultEncryption	Secret uses default AWS-managed key

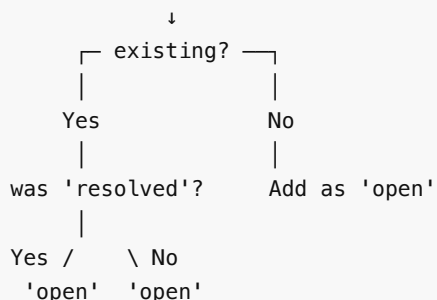
Evidence System

Each rule returns `evidence: Record<string, unknown>` with details about the violation. Example:

```
{
  "staleActiveKeys": [
    {
      "accessKeyId": "AKIA1234567890EXAMPLE",
      "ageDays": 120,
      "created": "2025-03-15T10:00:00Z"
    }
  ],
  "publicSshRules": [{
    "IpProtocol": "tcp",
    "FromPort": 22,
    "ToPort": 22,
    "IpRanges": [{ "CidrIp": "0.0.0.0/0" }]
  }]
}
```

Finding Lifecycle

New scan → findings detected



8. Scoring Engine

Score Calculation

Starting score: 100

- Critical: -20 each
- High: -10 each
- Medium: -4 each
- Low: -1 each

Clamp to: 0-100

Grade Mapping

Score Range	Grade
90–100	A
70–89	B
50–69	C
25–49	D
0–24	F

Delta Tracking

The scoring engine tracks changes from the previous scan:

```
Previous score: 85 (B)
Current score: 92 (A)
Delta:          +7
```

9. Code Generators

Terraform Generator

- Input: Finding
- Process: Looks up finding catalog → renders HCL template with resource values
- Template placeholders: `{{bucket}}`, `{{userName}}`, `{{accessKeyId}}`, `{{sgId}}`, `{{region}}`, `{{endpoint}}`

Example output for MCPS-S3-001:

```
resource "aws_s3_bucket_public_access_block" "my-bucket" {
  bucket                = "my-bucket"
  block_public_acls      = true
  block_public_policy    = true
  ignore_public_acls     = true
  restrict_public_buckets = true
}
```

AWS CLI Generator

- Same pattern as Terraform but outputs CLI commands
- Uses `--endpoint-url {{endpoint}}` for LocalStack compatibility

Example output for MCPS-S3-001:

```
aws --endpoint-url http://localhost:4566 s3api put-public-access-block \
  --bucket my-bucket \
  --public-access-block-configuration
BlockPublicAcls=true,IgnorePublicAcls=true,BlockPublicPolicy=true,RestrictPublicBucket:
```

Report Generator

- Takes ScanResult + SecurityScore + all Findings
- Outputs structured Markdown with:
 - Executive summary
 - Score and grade
 - Findings ranked by severity
 - Recommendations table
 - Remediation priority

10. Slack Bot Commands

Command Reference

Command	Description	MCP Tool Used
@Shield scan OR @Shield scan environment	Trigger full environment scan	scan_environment
@Shield show findings OR @Shield findings	List all findings	list_findings
@Shield show critical OR @Shield critical	List critical findings only	list_findings(severity:critical)
@Shield explain finding <id>	Get LLM-powered explanation	describe_finding + LLM
@Shield explain finding <id> eli5	Beginner-friendly explanation	describe_finding + eli5.ts
@Shield quiz me on finding <id>	Generate quiz questions	describe_finding + quiz.ts
@Shield generate terraform <id>	Generate Terraform fix	generate_terraform_fix
@Shield generate aws-cli <id>	Generate AWS CLI fix	generate_cli_fix
@Shield fix finding <id>	Approve + prepare remediation	approve_remediation
@Shield fix all critical	Batch approve critical findings	approve_remediation (batch)
@Shield approve	Execute approved remediation	execute_remediation
@Shield rescan	Re-scan environment	rescan_environment
@Shield security score OR @Shield score	Show current score	security_score
@Shield generate report OR @Shield report	Generate executive report	generate_report

Other text	Falls through to AI agent	LLM decides which tool to call
------------	---------------------------	--------------------------------

Agent Loop

When the LLM requests a tool call:

1. LLM returns toolCalls in response

2. Agent executes each tool via MCP client

3. Tool results are fed back to LLM

4. LLM formulates final response

11. API Endpoints

REST API

Method	Endpoint	Description
GET	/health	Server status
GET	/api/state	Full state (score, findings, remediations)
POST	/api/scan	Trigger scan (delegates to MCP server)
POST	/api/chat	AI chat with tool execution

State Endpoint Response

```
{
  "score": {
    "score": 85,
    "grade": "B",
    "totalFindings": 3,
    "breakdown": { "critical": 0, "high": 1, "medium": 1, "low": 1 }
  },
  "lastScan": {
    "scanId": "scn_abc123",
    "resourcesScanned": 45,
    "completedAt": "2026-07-20T10:00:00Z"
  },
  "findings": [ ... ],
  "approvals": [ ... ],
  "remediations": [ ... ]
}
```

Chat Endpoint

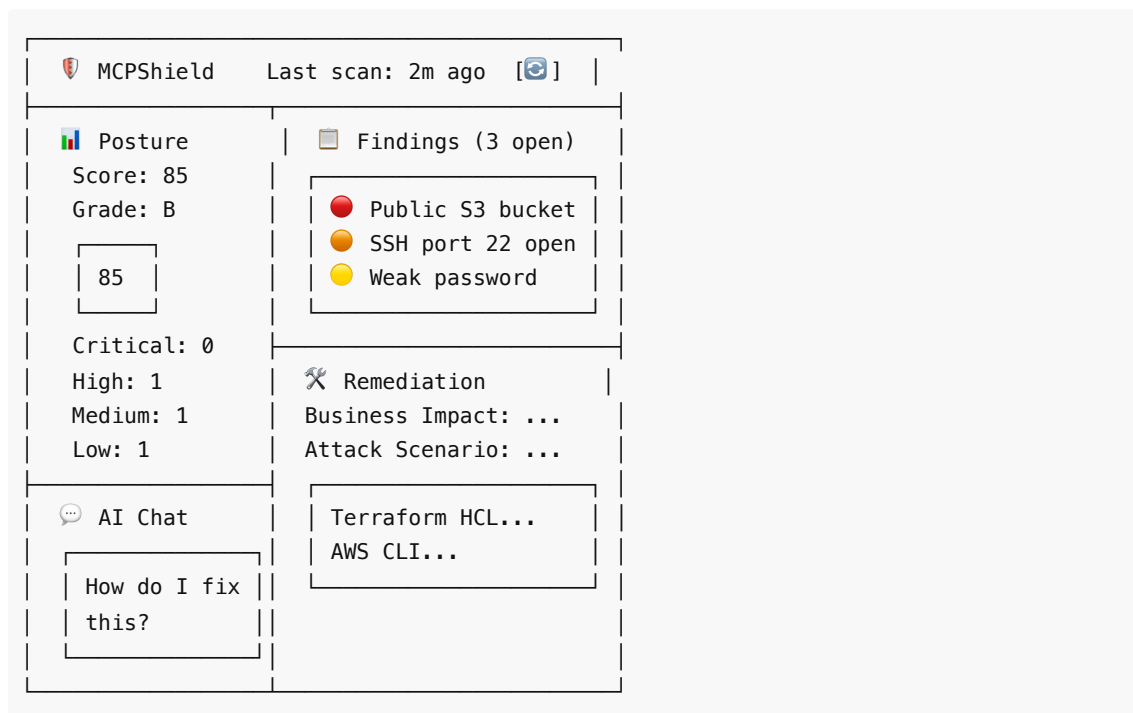
```
POST /api/chat
Body: { message: string, history?: array }
Response: { content: string }
```

Flow:

1. Create MCP Client → connect to MCP Server
2. Get LLM provider
3. List MCP tools
4. Call LLM with message + tool definitions
5. If LLM requests tool calls → execute via MCP Client
6. Feed results back to LLM
7. Return final response

12. Dashboard Walkthrough

Layout



Sections

1. **Header** — Logo, last scan time, refresh button
2. **Posture Card** — Score ring, grade badge, severity counters, resource stats
3. **Findings Card** — Filterable list (all/critical/high/medium/low)
4. **Remediation Card** — Finding detail, tabs (Description/Terraform/CLI), copy buttons
5. **Chat Card** — AI assistant conversation, text input

State Management

The dashboard polls `/api/state` every 5 seconds and re-renders.

13. Development Workflow

Local Development

```
# Terminal 1 – MCP Server
pnpm --filter @mcpshield/mcp-server dev

# Terminal 2 – API + Dashboard
pnpm --filter @mcpshield/api dev

# Terminal 3 (optional) – Slack Agent
pnpm --filter @mcpshield/agent dev
```

Build

```
pnpm build          # Build all packages + apps
```

Quality Checks

```
pnpm typecheck      # TypeScript strict mode check
pnpm lint            # ESLint
pnpm format:check    # Prettier
pnpm test            # Vitest
pnpm check           # All of the above
```

Package Management

```
pnpm add <pkg> --filter <workspace>  # Add dependency
pnpm -r build                          # Build all
pnpm --filter @mcpshield/api dev      # Run one app
```

Project Scripts

```
pnpm build    # tsc for all packages
pnpm clean    # Remove dist/ folders
pnpm test     # vitest for all packages
pnpm check    # typecheck + lint + format + test
```

14. Adding a New Security Rule

Step-by-Step

1. Add the rule function → `packages/security-engine/src/rules.ts`

```
export function checkNewRule(snapshot: ResourceSnapshot): RuleEvaluation | null {
  if (snapshot.service !== 's3' || snapshot.type !== 'bucket') return null;
  // ... check logic ...
  return { catalogId: 'MCPS-NEW-001', isViolated, evidence };
}
```


2. Register the rule → Add to the `RULES` array

```
export const RULES = [
  checkPublicS3Bucket,
  // ... existing rules ...
  checkNewRule,
];
```

3. Add catalog entry → `packages/finding-engine/src/catalog.ts`

```
{
  id: 'MCPS-NEW-001',
  title: 'New Security Rule',
  severity: 'medium',
  service: 's3',
  category: 'Data Protection',
  description: '...',
  businessImpact: '...',
  technicalImpact: '...',
  attackScenario: '...',
  bestPractice: '...',
  mitre: [{ tactic: '...', techniqueId: 'T...', techniqueName: '...' }],
  cis: [{ benchmark: '...', controlId: '...', title: '...' }],
  baseRiskScore: 50,
  remediation: {
    terraform: '...',
    awsCli: '...',
  },
  references: ['...'],
}
```

4. Add remediation mapping → `apps/mcp-server/src/server.ts`

```
case 'MCPS-NEW-001':
  return {
    findingId: finding.findingId,
    catalogId,
    description: `...`,
    service: 's3',
    operation: '...',
    params: { ... },
  };
```

5. Add dashboard catalog entry → `apps/dashboard/src/app.js`

6. Write tests → `packages/security-engine/src/engine.test.ts`

Rule Registration Options

- Any package exporting a `RuleFunction` type
- Registered in the `RULES` array in `rules.ts`

- Automatically picked up by `runSecurityEngine()`

15. Plugin Architecture & Cloud-Agnostic Design

Current State

MCPShield ships with an **AWS provider** only. The architecture is designed for extension:

```
interface CloudProvider {
  name: string;
  scan(): Promise<ResourceSnapshot[]>;
  remediate(action: RemediationAction): Promise<RemediationResult>;
}
```

Adding a New Provider

To add Azure support, you would:

1. Create `packages/azure-tools/` with Azure SDK scanner + remediator
2. Implement `CloudProvider` interface
3. Register in config: `CLOUD_PROVIDER=azure`
4. Add Azure-specific security rules
5. Update code generators for `az` CLI

Provider Configuration

```
CLOUD_PROVIDER=aws           # or azure, gcp
LOCALSTACK_ENDPOINT=...     # Used by AWS provider
AZURE_ENDPOINT=...          # Used by Azure provider
```

Universal Security Rules

Some rules are provider-agnostic:

- Tagging compliance
- Naming conventions
- Encryption at rest
- Audit logging enablement
- Public access controls

These could be shared across providers with provider-specific check implementations.

Appendix A: Key Terms

Term	Definition
MCP	Model Context Protocol — open protocol for AI-tool communication
CSPM	Cloud Security Posture Management — continuous compliance monitoring
JSON-RPC	Lightweight remote procedure call protocol using JSON

SSE	Server-Sent Events — HTTP push technology
STDIO	Standard input/output — process communication channel
HCL	HashiCorp Configuration Language — Terraform syntax
MITRE ATT&CK	Knowledge base of adversary tactics and techniques
CIS Benchmark	Center for Internet Security configuration guidelines
Zod	TypeScript-first schema validation library
Fastify	Fast Node.js HTTP framework
Pino	Low-overhead Node.js logger
Vitest	Unit test framework for Vite projects
pnpm	Fast, disk-efficient package manager

Appendix B: Environment Variables

Variable	Default	Purpose
NODE_ENV	development	Runtime environment
LOG_LEVEL	info	Logging verbosity
LOCALSTACK_ENDPOINT	http://localhost:4566	AWS endpoint
AWS_ACCESS_KEY_ID	test	AWS credentials
AWS_SECRET_ACCESS_KEY	test	AWS credentials
AWS_DEFAULT_REGION	us-east-1	AWS region
MCP_TRANSPORT	http	Stdio or HTTP SSE
MCP_HTTP_HOST	0.0.0.0	MCP server bind
MCP_HTTP_PORT	7801	MCP server port
MCP_SERVER_URL	http://localhost:7801/mcp	SSE endpoint
MCPSHIELD_STATE_DIR	./mcpshield-state	State file directory
API_HOST	0.0.0.0	API bind address
API_PORT	7802	API server port
LLM_PROVIDER	nim	LLM provider selection
LLM_TEMPERATURE	0.1	LLM temperature
LLM_MAX_TOKENS	1024	Max response tokens
NIM_API_KEY	—	NVIDIA NIM API key

GEMINI_API_KEY	–	Google Gemini API key
SLACK_BOT_TOKEN	–	Slack bot token
SLACK_APP_TOKEN	–	Slack app token

Appendix C: MCPShield File Reference

File	Purpose	Key Functions
apps/mcp-server/src/server.ts	MCP tool implementations	performScanAndSave(), mapFindingToRemediation()
apps/mcp-server/src/state.ts	State persistence	loadState(), saveState()
apps/mcp-server/src/index.ts	HTTP/SSE transport	Fastify server, SSE endpoint
apps/agent/src/slack.ts	Slack bot handlers	15 command handlers
apps/agent/src/llm.ts	LLM provider re-export	getLlmProvider()
apps/agent/src/mcp-client.ts	Agent MCP client	STDIO + SSE transport
apps/api/src/index.ts	REST API endpoints	/api/state, /api/scan, /api/chat
apps/api/src/mcp-client.ts	API MCP client	STDIO + SSE transport
packages/aws-tools/src/scanner.ts	AWS resource scanning	scanEnvironment()
packages/aws-tools/src/remediator.ts	AWS remediation execution	executeRemediationAction()
packages/security-engine/src/rules.ts	21 security rules	All check*() functions
packages/security-engine/src/engine.ts	Rule orchestrator	runSecurityEngine()
packages/scoring-engine/src/scoring.ts	Score calculation	computeSecurityScore()
packages/finding-engine/src/catalog.ts	Finding definitions	21 catalog entries
packages/llm/src/index.ts	Shared LLM adapters	OpenAIBcompatibleProvider, OllamaProvider
packages/config/src/index.ts	Config loader	loadConfig(), getConfig()